of a rather rocky debate.

All on account of another, quasi-political force: the Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama. A century-old body of traditional Sunni scholars with a vast network, it has put on the main stage of Kerala a diktat that had all the force of a Shariatic worldview. One not entirely in conformity with the complex ways in which Muslim society here is evolving—uniquely combining markers of traditionalism and modernity.

Right after Eid, Samastha had put out a circular advising its local units to ensure they limit the participation of women on public stages. "Young women mingling with unrelated men in public is not appropriate for believers and is not permissible," it said. In part a reaction to Eid celebrations increasingly spilling over to secular spaces such as youth clubs, the wording immediately drew the ire of commentators and women's groups from the community.



"We do not agree at all that if women enter the public sphere, it will cause great ruin. This is not the 19th century, and even Islam doesn't say so. Women should be part of mainstream life in every way"

V.D. SATHEESAN
Chief Minister, Kerala

Faced with the backlash, the grand old man of Samastha doubled down at an event in Kochi. Thus spake Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliyar, the redoubtable 87-year-old 'Grand Mufti of India': "Bringing women onto public platforms causes great destruction. Women should live confined within their homes." He invoked purdah, and said that as religious scholars "we have an obligation to say it. We will say it and continue to say it. No one can stop us."

SATHEESAN SPEAKS OUT

That intensified the backlash. But it hit the circuit barrier on September 2, when Satheesan issued a clear, unambiguous denunciation, saying the scholar was articulating an outdated "19th-century mindset" incompatible with modern Kerala. "Women are meant to be part of mainstream life in every way. This is the progressive stand we endorse," he added. For good measure, he invoked the Prophet's wives, pointing out that Khadija was a businesswoman and Aisha took part in military leadership.

The IUML was patently discomfited. It's deeply enmeshed with Samastha, even if the ties are not without strain. Samastha is split into two—Kanthapuram heads his own AP faction, and has leaned leftward in the past to counter IUML dominance. The rival EK faction is closer to the IUML. But handed such a stark choice, even that side was drawn into backing Kanthapuram's "right" to preach Islamic principles. IUML state chief and spiritual leader Panakkad Shihab Thangal, offering a qualified endorsement, said the mufti may have spoken in a protective vein.

The BJP, denied a chance to throw darts at the CM, raked up Rahul's "silence", calling it "selective feminism" and proof of its debt to Muslim support. On public evidence, though, ordinary Muslims—unlike the clergy—are not out of rhythm with the rest of Kerala and are in no need of special tutoring. ■



◂ HEAVY HANDED
AP Kanthapuram Aboobacker Musliyar and (right) Onam celebrations in Kerala, Aug. 20